

Tropidophorus grayi

Gray's keeled water skink



Length 8–10 in
(20–25 cm)
Breeding Viviparous
Habit Semiaquatic
Status Least concern

Location Philippines



This slender skink has strongly keeled scales on its back that end in a spine, producing a spiky appearance. Its tail is about the same length as the head and body. It lives in cool conditions, in and around mountain streams, often under rotting logs. If in danger, it may jump into the water and hide under stones on the streambed. Although it is a relatively common skink, little is known about its social and reproductive behavior, except for the fact that the female gives birth to 1–6 young.

*Ameiva ameiva*

Common ameiva



Length 18–20 in
(45–50 cm)
Breeding Oviparous
Habit Terrestrial
Status Not evaluated

Location Central America,
N. and C. South America



The common ameiva has a streamlined body with a pointed head and a very long tail that may be twice the length of the body. The male, which is more slender and brightly colored than the female, has a bright green area down the center of his back. The female lays several clutches of 2–6 eggs throughout an extended breeding season (March–December). Common ameivas live in loose colonies in forest openings, on the edges of roads and paths, and in cultivated land, usually near human habitation. They bask in patches of sunlight, and shelter under leaf litter or logs on cool days.

Aspidoscelis uniparens

Desert grassland whiptail lizard

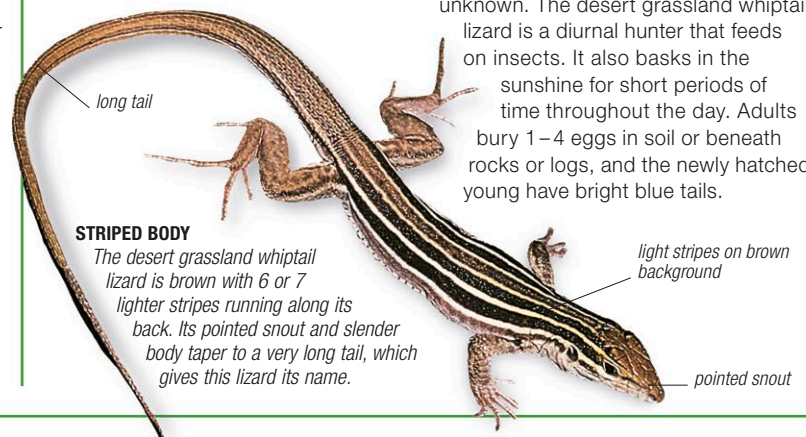


Length 6–9 in
(15–23 cm)
Breeding Oviparous
Habit Terrestrial
Status Least concern

Location S. USA,
N. Mexico



Found in deserts, grassland, and scrub, this is one of over a dozen very similar lizards that live in North America. It has a long, slender, striped body and whiplike tail, but its most remarkable feature—shared by several other whiptails—is that it is an



entirely female species: males are unknown. The desert grassland whiptail lizard is a diurnal hunter that feeds on insects. It also basks in the sunshine for short periods of time throughout the day. Adults bury 1–4 eggs in soil or beneath rocks or logs, and the newly hatched young have bright blue tails.

Tupinambis teguixin

Black tegu



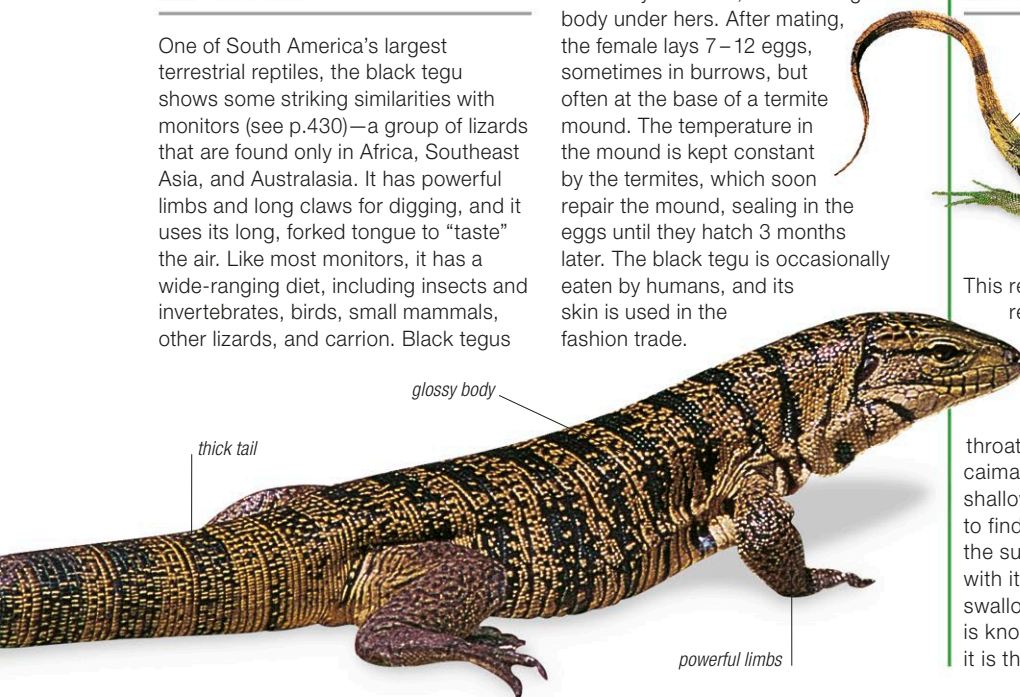
Length 32–43 in
(80–110 cm)
Breeding Oviparous
Habit Terrestrial
Status Not evaluated

Location N. to C. South
America



One of South America's largest terrestrial reptiles, the black tegu shows some striking similarities with monitors (see p.430)—a group of lizards that are found only in Africa, Southeast Asia, and Australasia. It has powerful limbs and long claws for digging, and it uses its long, forked tongue to "taste" the air. Like most monitors, it has a wide-ranging diet, including insects and invertebrates, birds, small mammals, other lizards, and carrion. Black tegus

live in forest clearings and on riverbanks, and are good swimmers. When confronted by predators—usually large, carnivorous mammals such as cats, or lizards and snakes when juvenile—they bite and scratch with their claws, and also use their tails as clubs. They walk on their hind legs, and communicate with each other by making loud, snoring noises, which carry a long way in still air. Mating involves the male grasping the female by her neck, and twisting his body under hers. After mating, the female lays 7–12 eggs, sometimes in burrows, but often at the base of a termite mound. The temperature in the mound is kept constant by the termites, which soon repair the mound, sealing in the eggs until they hatch 3 months later. The black tegu is occasionally eaten by humans, and its skin is used in the fashion trade.

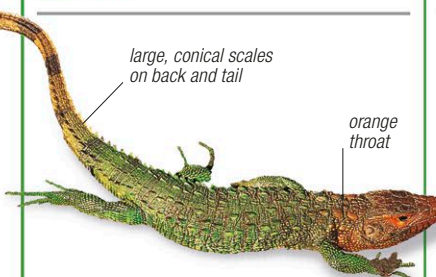
*Dracaena guianensis*

Caiman lizard



Length 3–3 1/2 ft
(0.9–1.1 m)
Breeding Oviparous
Habit Semiaquatic/
Arboreal
Status Not evaluated

Location N. South
America



This relatively large lizard resembles a short-headed crocodilian. It is greenish or brown, with yellow or tan blotches on its flanks. The male has an orange and black throat, while the female's is gray. The caiman lizard dives to the bottom of shallow rivers, lakes, and streams to find water snails, which it brings to the surface before crushing the shells with its large, flattened teeth, and swallowing the soft contents. Little is known about this rare reptile, but it is thought to lay eggs.

Xantusia henshawi

Granite night lizard



Length 2–2 1/4 in
(5–7 cm)
Breeding Viviparous
Habit Terrestrial
Status Least concern

Location S.W. USA
(S. California), Mexico
(Baja California)



This nocturnal lizard has a flattened body that enables it to squeeze under exfoliating rock flakes. It is covered with tiny scales that are yellowish in color, with many large, black spots. This lizard actively forages over rock surfaces at night, retreating into narrow crevices when threatened by predators. Although it is not particularly rare, this species is protected because collectors destroy its habitat by removing rock flakes to expose the lizards.

